# *Defending Saudi Arabia preserves geopolitical alignment*

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## 【メール原文】

Cairo will expand its defense backing to Saudi Arabia but stop short of major offensive support. Egypt has reportedly deployed air defense and fighter

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Defending Saudi Arabia preserves geopolitical alignment and financial ties

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Cairo will seek to keep its military support for Saudi Arabia defensive to avoid becoming involved in regional wars, but the risk of involvement has increased since President Abdelfattah el Sisi publicly asked parliament on 17 October to authorize the defense of the kingdom by all necessary means.
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Egypt will use its backing to discourage Riyadh from seeking Israeli military support and to preserve the kingdom's alignment with Cairo on regional issues.
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Renewal of Saudi Arabia's $5.3 billion deposit at the Egyptian Central Bank, and the need to preserve Saudi-sourced remittances (a third of the total), provide additional motivation for Cairo's commitment, though geopolitical concerns remain the priority.

Cairo will expand its defense backing to Saudi Arabia but stop short of major offensive support. Egypt has reportedly deployed air defense and fighter jets to Saudi Arabia since the start of the US-Iran war. It will provide additional assets to help intercept drone and missile attacks against the kingdom from the Houthis or Iraqi Shia militias. Egypt is unlikely to deploy ground troops to Yemen to fight the Houthis given the risk of heavy losses. It is also unlikely to carry out overt airstrikes against the Houthis, since that could escalate into a broader costly war in Yemen, which the Egyptian public strongly opposes.

Parliament, which postponed its vote to 26 October, will likely approve Sisi's request. Opposition members are too few to block approval, and parliament will likely stress the defensive nature of the support. The National Defense Council—which comprises military and intelligence leadership, the speaker of the parliament, the prime minister, and several ministers—has already approved Sisi's request.

Egypt wants to stay out of regional wars, but the risk of involvement has risen. Cairo wants to stay out of the US-Iran war and has reportedly communicated that to Tehran since it sent military assets to the Gulf months ago. Egypt is also keeping its Saudi support strictly defensive to avoid retaliation from Iran-backed militias against Egyptian territory. The strike on US ships in Egyptian waters last July showed that such attacks are feasible (see: Cairo will stay out of US-Iran war despite suffering drone

attack , 30 July 2026). After Sisi's request, the Houthis warned that aggression against them will threaten Egypt's national security and domestic stability. The risk of a Houthi attack on Egyptian territory or interests remains low if Cairo limits its support for Riyadh to defensive measures.

Sending additional military assets to Saudi Arabia heightens the risk of drawing Cairo into war. If these defensive assets suffer significant losses, Egypt would likely have to respond against the Houthis or Iraqi militias, pulling it deeper into the conflict. Similarly, if the US-Iran war escalates after the US midterms, potential Iranian attacks on Saudi Arabia and losses to Egyptian assets could also risk drawing Cairo into a confrontation with Tehran (see: Hormuz attacks likely to compel US escalation after midterms , 15 October 2026). However, that risk remains lower given the level of Egyptian-Iranian communication.

Cairo wants to reduce Riyadh's incentive to seek Israeli military support. Sisi's decision partly aims to discourage Saudi Arabia from turning to Israel as Houthi attacks intensify. Saudi Arabia and Israel have reportedly explored military and intelligence coordination since the war against the Houthis escalated. Cairo views Israel's expanding regional military presence and partnerships across the Gulf, the Horn of Africa, and Morocco as potential threats to Egyptian national security. By strengthening Saudi defenses, Egypt hopes to limit further Israeli involvement in its neighborhood.

Egypt still prefers to remain outside the Mecca Defense Alliance. Despite broader alignment with Saudi Arabia, Turkey, and Pakistan within the informal Quartet framework, Cairo seeks to maintain flexibility in its regional defense commitments and provide military support on a case-by-case basis. Joining the Mecca Alliance offers few additional benefits at present. Bilateral defense backing, by contrast, preserves Egypt's ties with the kingdom, supports a close partner that shares Cairo's position on many regional issues, and avoids broader regional commitments.

Financial motives reinforce Egypt's commitment. Cairo and Riyadh are negotiating the renewal of a $5.3 billion Saudi deposit at Egypt's central bank, due this October, and Sisi's decision makes renewal more likely. The kingdom also hosts around 4 million Egyptians—workers and their families—who accounted for 33% of Egypt's remittance inflows in 2024/2025. Remittances remain important to the Egyptian economy, totaling $33.9 billion in the first eight months of 2026. A prolonged war would threaten those workers' safety and earnings as pressure on the Saudi economy grows.

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